

WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Mochar Ghonto

❀

Banana Flower Delicacy

The Labor of Love Dish of Rural Bengal

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Mochar Ghonto

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Mochar Ghonto

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Delicacy Earned Through Patience

Of all the dishes in Bengali cuisine, few demand as much patience before they even reach the stove as mochar ghonto — made from mocha, the purple-red flower of the banana plant. Preparing the flower is genuinely tedious work: each individual floret must be carefully cleaned of its bitter, fibrous outer layers and tiny stamens, a process that can take the better part of an hour for a single flower, which is likely why this dish has historically been associated with grandmothers and the unhurried rhythms of rural Bengali kitchens rather than quick weeknight cooking.

That labor is rewarded, though — banana flower has a delicate, slightly nutty flavor and a satisfying texture once cooked down with coconut, ginger, and warm spices, and it's also notably nutritious, rich in fiber and traditionally valued in Bengali households for its health benefits, including folk beliefs around its usefulness for women's health.

Because of the effort involved, and because fresh banana flowers can be difficult to source outside regions where banana cultivation is common, mochar ghonto has retained a certain special-occasion, delicacy status even within Bengal itself — a dish many families reserve for a leisurely Sunday rather than a routine weekday meal.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Delicacy Earned Through Patience, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Historically associated with the patient, unhurried cooking style of rural Bengali households and grandmothers, given the labor-intensive preparation required. Valued in Bengali food tradition for its nutritional benefits, including folk associations with women's health. Considered a delicacy even within Bengal, often reserved for leisurely weekend cooking rather than routine weeknights, due to the significant prep time involved. A dish that showcases the Bengali culinary tradition of transforming humble, labor-intensive ingredients into genuinely special dishes.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

45–60m	25m	4	Hard
CLEANING PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- A bowl of water with a little lemon juice or turmeric, for soaking cleaned florets
- Sharp knife
- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Mochar ghonto keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days. It doesn't freeze particularly well, as the banana flower's texture can turn unpleasantly soft after thawing — best enjoyed fresh or within a few days of cooking.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Banana flower (mocha), cleaned and chopped	1 medium	300 g	1 medium
Potato, diced small	1 medium	120 g	1 medium
Coconut, grated or finely chopped	¼ cup	30 g	¼ katori
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Panch phoron	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Ginger paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Cumin powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Green chili, slit	2	2	2
Sugar	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Ghee, to finish	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Fresh banana flower can be found at South Asian and Southeast Asian grocers, often labeled "banana blossom." Frozen or canned banana blossom, increasingly available at larger international grocers, is a genuinely useful shortcut that saves considerable cleaning time, though the texture differs slightly from fresh. When handling fresh banana flower, rub your hands and knife with a little oil or lemon water, as the flower releases a sticky, staining sap.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cleaning the Banana Flower

01 REMOVE THE OUTER LAYERS

Peel away the tough, purple outer bracts of the banana flower until you reach the pale, tender florets inside. This is the most labor-intensive part of the dish — take your time.

02 CLEAN EACH FLORET

For each individual floret, remove the small hard stamen and the translucent, fibrous covering — these are bitter and tough if left in. Chop the cleaned florets finely.



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Cleaning the Banana Flower, continued

Chef tip. keep a bowl of water with a little lemon juice or turmeric nearby, and drop the cleaned, chopped florets in as you go — this prevents discoloration and reduces the flower's natural sap stickiness.

03 DRAIN BEFORE COOKING

Once all the florets are cleaned and chopped, drain thoroughly before adding to the pan.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

Properly cleaned banana flower should have no hard stamens or fibrous strands remaining — take a moment to check a handful before proceeding, as any missed pieces will be unpleasantly tough in the finished dish.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Ghonto

04 TEMPER THE PANCH PHORON

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and temper the panch phoron and bay leaf until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

05 ADD POTATO AND AROMATICS

Add the diced potato, ginger paste, turmeric, and cumin powder, stirring to coat. Cook for 5 minutes.

06 ADD THE BANANA FLOWER

Add the cleaned, chopped banana flower along with the green chilies. Cook covered for 15–18 minutes, stirring occasionally, until both the potato and banana flower are completely tender.

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Cooking the Ghonto, continued



07 ADD COCONUT AND FINISH

Stir in the coconut, sugar, and salt, cooking uncovered for a final 5 minutes to let any excess moisture evaporate. Finish with a spoonful of ghee just before serving.

Texture indicator. finished mochar ghonto should be dry rather than saucy, with a soft, slightly fibrous texture similar to a well-cooked cabbage or minced vegetable dish.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Ghonto, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Skipping thorough cleaning of the florets, especially leaving the stamens in, results in an unpleasantly tough, fibrous bite. Take the extra time during prep — it makes a real difference in the final dish.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with plain steamed rice and a wedge of lemon, a beloved weekend delicacy in Bengali households.
- Often part of a larger, more elaborate Sunday lunch spread given the effort involved in its preparation.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl as a specialty item on Bengali restaurant menus, given its labor-intensive reputation.

Family Style

- A special dish made together as a family activity, given the time-consuming cleaning process, then enjoyed as a shared delicacy.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Prep Right

- Thorough cleaning is genuinely the difference between a delicacy and a disappointing, fibrous dish — don't rush this step.
- Keeping cleaned florets in acidulated water prevents discoloration and makes the final dish visually appealing.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The cleaning process can be done a day ahead, with cleaned florets refrigerated in water until you're ready to cook.
- Consider cleaning banana flower in a larger batch when you have the time, and freezing portions for future use to save effort later.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Bengali cooks add a handful of small dried shrimp for a non-vegetarian version with extra umami depth — an optional variation for those who eat seafood, though the vegetarian version stands well on its own.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

175 kcal	4 g	18 g	10 g	7 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Mochar Ghonto with Coconut	the classic version featured here, with generous coconut for richness.
Mochar Chop	banana flower mixture shaped into patties and shallow-fried, a popular snack variation.
Mochar Ghonto with Dried Shrimp	a non-vegetarian variation adding small dried shrimp for umami depth.

Can I use canned or frozen banana blossom?

Yes — increasingly available at international grocers, it saves significant cleaning time, though fresh gives the most traditional texture.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why does my banana flower turn brown?

Banana flower oxidizes quickly once cut — keep cleaned florets in water with a little lemon juice or turmeric until ready to cook.

Is this dish difficult to make?

The cooking itself is straightforward; the real challenge is the time-consuming cleaning process, which requires patience more than skill.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Mocha	Bengali for banana flower, the star ingredient of this dish.
Ghonto	a Bengali cooking style referring to a mixed, minced-style vegetable preparation.
Panch Phoron	a Bengali five-spice blend used to temper this dish.
Sorshe Tel	Bengali for mustard oil, used throughout for its distinctive pungent flavor.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Mochar Ghonto

45–60m	25m
CLEANING PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Hard**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Banana flower	300 g
Potato	120 g
Coconut	30 g
Mustard oil	45 ml
Panch phoron	3 g
Bay leaf	1
Ginger paste	15 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Cumin powder	1.5 g
Green chili	2
Sugar	4 g
Salt	6 g
Ghee	15 g

METHOD

01 **Remove the outer layers.** Peel away the tough, purple outer bracts of the banana flower until you reach the pale, tender florets inside.

02 **Clean each floret.** For each individual floret, remove the small hard stamen and the translucent, fibrous covering — these are bitter and tough if left in.

03 **Drain before cooking.** Once all the florets are cleaned and chopped, drain thoroughly before adding to the pan.

04 **Temper the panch phoron.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and temper the panch phoron and bay leaf until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

05 **Add potato and aromatics.** Add the diced potato, ginger paste, turmeric, and cumin powder, stirring to coat.

06 **Add the banana flower.** Add the cleaned, chopped banana flower along with the green chilies.

07 **Add coconut and finish.** Stir in the coconut, sugar, and salt, cooking uncovered for a final 5 minutes to let any excess moisture evaporate.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Banana flower	300 g	
☐	Coconut	30 g	
☐	Panch phoron	3 g	
☐	Ginger paste	15 g	
☐	Cumin powder	1.5 g	
☐	Sugar	4 g	
☐	Ghee	15 g	
☐	Potato	120 g	
☐	Mustard oil	45 ml	
☐	Bay leaf	1	
☐	Turmeric powder	1.5 g	
☐	Green chili	2	
☐	Salt	6 g	

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